

Curriculum Prioritisation

Games & VFX Art Roles

What should art & tech-art programmes actually teach? This summary distils a survey of industry professionals — predominantly senior practitioners with a hiring-manager perspective — into the findings that recurred across every sector.

Survey & analysis by **Makis Stergiou** • March 2026 • 17-question instrument

230

industry professionals
responded

64%

senior / lead
or director / head

69%

games • 20% film/VFX
11% hybrid & other

01 T-shaped graduates are the industry standard

Broad pipeline literacy plus one deep specialisation was the most-valued hiring outcome in every sector. Pure specialists ranked last.

02 Technical Artist leads Games; Pipeline TD leads Film

Normalised for industry share, these art-meets-engineering hybrid roles top the 3–5 year demand outlook — and stay #1 even after removing self-referencing respondents.

03 Foundations before tools

A 50/50 blend of art fundamentals and digital tools in Year 1 was the clear consensus, taught principles-first then deepened in key tools.

04 AI is a tool, not a foundation

Despite heavy AI discussion elsewhere, only **1.7%** named AI a non-negotiable core concept. Teamwork & collaboration topped that list at 29%.

05 Industry awareness is the biggest graduate gap

At **27%**, "not understanding how production actually works" was the single most-cited deficiency — ahead of technical skills and portfolio focus.

SECTION 01

What the data says to teach

FOUNDATIONAL ARCHITECTURE

- **Year 1: 50/50 art + digital.** Embed professional practice — version control, shot tracking, asset management — from day one, and start scaling-complexity collaborative projects immediately.
- **Principles-first software.** Teach colour theory, topology and physically-based rendering before tool-specific workflows; deepen industry-standard tools as students specialise.
- **T-shaped as the explicit outcome.** Every student builds broad pipeline literacy and demonstrable depth in one specialisation by graduation, reflected in the portfolio.

SPECIALISATION PATHWAYS

- **Games track:** Technical Art, Performance & Optimisation, real-time VFX, Rigging, Lighting and Environment Art.
- **Film / VFX track:** Pipeline TD, FX (Houdini), Compositing, generalist modelling and Lighting.
- **Safest long-term bets** (demanded across all industries): Technical Artist, Pipeline TD, generalist 3D, Environment Art, Compositor, Performance & Optimisation.

TECHNICAL CURRICULUM

- **Pipeline scripting (Python) is the #1 critical sub-discipline.** Integrate it inside art courses via the preferred integrated-learning model rather than isolating it in standalone modules.
- **Houdini / procedural** as a specialisation pathway rather than a universal requirement — with broader coverage on Film-oriented tracks.

CLOSING THE SKILLS GAP

- **Industry immersion** through studio visits, guest lectures and production simulations to tackle the #1 gap, industry awareness.
- **Quality benchmarking** against shipped titles and released shots, plus focused, specialisation-aligned portfolios over unfocused generalism.

SECTION 02

The evidence base

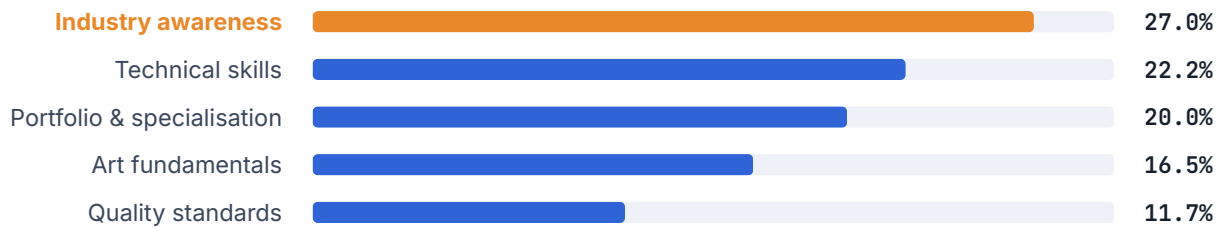
Non-negotiable core concepts

Share of 229 open responses naming each as essential. Human and craft skills dominate; AI ranks last.



Biggest graduate skills gaps

Most-cited weaknesses in new entrants. Understanding production reality outranks raw technical skill.



Specialisation demand • 3–5 year outlook

Top roles for well-trained juniors, by industry.

GAMES

- 1 Technical Artist ~28%
- 2 Performance & Optimisation
- 3 Real-time VFX Artist
- 4 Rigging Artist
- 5 Lighting Artist
- 6 Environment / Level Art

FILM / VFX

- 1 Pipeline TD
- 2 FX Artist (Houdini)
- 3 Compositor
- 4 Generalist Modeler
- 5 Lighting Artist
- 6 Animator

SECTION 03

AI's place & the market reality

How the community views AI

Sentiment leans cautiously optimistic — AI as a layer on top of fundamentals, not a replacement for them.



EXTERNAL VALIDATION

The survey's headline demand signals are corroborated by external labour-market data. Technical Artist and Pipeline TD sit at the art-engineering intersection studios are hiring into, and nearly 90% of games companies now use generative AI — but as hybrid roles, not standalone "AI artist" titles. The market context sharpens the case for focused, specialisation-aligned portfolios:



THE TAKEAWAY

In a tighter, AI-shaped market, the winning graduate profile is unchanged and clearer than ever: **broad pipeline literacy, one deep technical edge, and the production awareness to use it.** Build curricula around fundamentals first, specialise deliberately, and treat AI as a workflow layer — not a foundation.